



Halloween on \$50

A cozy, spooky, grandma-approved Halloween
for your porch, your house, your costume and your party
without blowing the budget.

by Holly Bramble · @hollydaysathome

"It doesn't have to be perfect. It has to be ours."

Hi, I'm Holly

My grandmother ran Halloween like a general. Homemade costumes, a porch that scared the mail carrier, and a pot of cider that never ran out. When it was my turn to carry it on, I had a teacher's budget and zero plan. So I made one.

This guide is that plan. It splits **fifty dollars** across the four things that actually make Halloween feel like Halloween, gives you a week-by-week timeline so nothing sneaks up on you, and shows you every DIY I'd do again.

How to use this guide: Read the budget page, pick your projects, then follow the 4-week timeline. Print the shopping list and take it to the store. If it's not on the list, it's not coming home.

Prices are typical US dollar-store and big-box prices; yours may vary a little. Holly is an AI-generated character; every project here is a real, simple DIY you can make yourself.

The \$50 Budget

Bucket	Budget	What it covers
 Porch & outside	\$18	The first thing trick-or-treaters see. Biggest bang for your buck.
 Inside the house	\$10	Mantel, table, one "wow" corner.
 Costume(s)	\$10	Homemade, from the closet plus one or two buys.
 Treats & party	\$12	Candy for the door, cider, one easy snack.
Total	\$50	

Holly's three money rules

1. **Free first.** Before you buy anything, raid the house: old sheets, jars, sticks from the yard, cardboard boxes, the black clothes in the back of your closet.
2. **Buy what runs out, not what lasts.** In October buy lights, candy and cheesecloth. Buy skeletons, signs and big decor on **November 1st**, when it's half off or more, and save them for next year.
3. **One "wow," not ten "meh."** Put most of your effort into one spot people will remember: the porch or the mantel.



The Porch — \$18

1. Cheesecloth ghosts — \$3

One pack of cheesecloth makes 3–4 ghosts. Blow up a balloon, set it on a bottle, drape the cheesecloth over it, and spray with a mix of half glue, half water. Let dry overnight, pop the balloon, and add two felt or paper eyes. Hang them from the eaves with fishing line so they move in the wind.

2. Orange string lights — \$5

One 100-bulb string outlines the door or railing. Lights do more for a porch at night than anything else on this list.

3. Black-painted pumpkins — \$4.50

Ask neighbors, farm stands or friends for extra pumpkins (lots of people grow too many). A can of matte black spray paint turns mismatched pumpkins into a "designer" stack. Leave one or two orange for contrast.

4. Glowing jar luminaries — \$3

Save glass jars from the recycling. Wrap with masking tape "bandages," or paint them orange and draw jack-o'-lantern faces with a marker. Drop in battery tea lights (a 12-pack is about \$3).

5. Stick-and-twine "spider web" — \$2

Tie three yard sticks into a triangle, then wrap twine in a spiral. Hang it in a corner of the porch.

Total: about \$17.50. Spend the last 50 cents on zip ties. You'll need them.



Inside — \$10

The mantel or table "wow" — \$6

- Clip bare branches from the yard and put them in a jar or vase. Hang paper bats from them.
- **Paper bats:** trace a bat on cardboard, cut 20 from black construction paper (about \$1), fold the wings slightly, and tape them going up a wall like they're flying out of the fireplace.
- Add 3 dollar-store candlesticks spray-painted black, plus your jar luminaries.

Spooky windows — \$2

Cut silhouettes from black paper (a cat, a witch on a broom, a few bats) and tape them inside your front windows. They look great from the street at night with the lights on inside.

The "potion shelf" — \$2

Soak the labels off old bottles, fill them with water and a drop of food coloring, and add handwritten tags like "Eye of Newt" and "Bat Breath." Free if you have the coloring.



Costumes — \$10

Grandma's rule: **every costume is homemade, even if it's terrible.** Mine were terrible. One year I was a pillowcase. Here are five that actually look good, built from what's already in your closet.

Costume	From the closet	Buy	Cost
Black cat	Black clothes	Felt for ears on a headband, eyeliner whiskers	\$2
Scarecrow	Flannel shirt, jeans, old hat	Raffia or straw sticking out of cuffs, face paint	\$3
Classic ghost	An old white sheet	Nothing. Cut eyeholes and you're done.	\$0
Witch	Black dress or top	Witch hat, broom from the garage	\$3
Skeleton	Black long sleeves and leggings	White fabric paint for the bones	\$3

For a family of four, pick two \$2–3 costumes and two \$0 ones and you'll stay at \$10.



Treats & Party — \$12

Candy for the door — \$8

Buy the biggest mixed bag of fun-size candy you can for about \$8. That's usually 50–70 pieces, enough for a normal street. Hand out one or two at a time. Too many trick-or-treaters? Switch to a bowl of glow sticks (a 15-pack is about \$1).

Cider + one snack — \$4

- **Slow-cooker cider:** apple juice, a cinnamon stick, a few cloves and an orange slice. Keep it warm all night.
- **Mummy dogs** (hot dogs wrapped in strips of crescent dough), or "**monster mash**" **popcorn** with candy corn and pretzels.

Grandma's Rule #2: leave the porch light on late. Some kid out there has nobody to take them around, and they still deserve the good candy. Save a few of the best pieces for the last knock of the night.

The 4-Week Timeline

When	Do this	Done
Week 1 (4 weeks out)	Raid the house: sheets, jars, sticks, black clothes. Pick your projects and costumes. Ask the neighbors for extra pumpkins. Make your shopping list (next page).	☐
Week 2 (3 weeks out)	One shopping trip, list only. Make the cheesecloth ghosts (they need overnight drying). Paint the pumpkins and candlesticks.	☐
Week 3 (2 weeks out)	Cut the bats and window silhouettes. Build the luminaries and potion shelf. Finish the costumes and try them on.	☐
Week 4 (final week)	Hang the lights, ghosts and web. Set up the mantel. Buy the candy no earlier than 3 days before, so nobody "taste-tests" it all.	☐
Halloween day	Start the cider at 3pm. Test the lights at dusk. Put the porch light on. Enjoy it, because it doesn't have to be perfect.	☐
Nov 1	Go shopping for next year at 50–90% off: skeletons, signs, big decor. Store everything in one labeled bin.	☐



The Shopping List

Item	Est.	Actual
☐ Cheesecloth (1 pack)	\$3.00	_____
☐ Orange string lights	\$5.00	_____
☐ Matte black spray paint	\$4.50	_____
☐ Battery tea lights (12)	\$3.00	_____
☐ Twine + zip ties	\$2.50	_____
☐ Black construction paper	\$1.00	_____
☐ Candlesticks (3)	\$3.00	_____
☐ Food coloring / labels	\$2.00	_____
☐ Costume extras (felt, paint, hat)	\$10.00	_____
☐ Candy (big mixed bag)	\$8.00	_____
☐ Cider + snack ingredients	\$4.00	_____
Total	\$46.00	_____

That leaves about \$4 as a cushion for prices that run high in your area.

Grandma's Three Rules

1. **Every costume is homemade, even if it's terrible.** Your kids won't remember the store-bought one. They'll remember the year they were a pillowcase.
2. **Leave the porch light on late.** Save the good candy for the last knock.
3. **Nobody eats until everybody's home.** Halloween ends at the table, together.

Make your own rule: write one tradition your family will do every single year.

What's next

Thanksgiving is coming fast. If this made October easier, my **Stress-Free Thanksgiving Planner** does the same thing for the big dinner: a 3-week countdown, the shopping list, a make-ahead plan and seating cards. It's in my bio.

And tag me in your porch. I want to see your sad-napkin ghosts. 🧛

It doesn't have to be perfect. It has to be ours.
— Holly

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Holly is an AI-generated character. Always follow the label directions on paints and glue, and never leave real candles unattended.